WHAT'S NEW • 2026

Open Foris Arena

A year of new features, from survey design to data analysis

Open Foris · November 2026

2026 AT A GLANCE

A year of steady releases

71

Arena releases

from v2.2.13 to v2.12.0

18

headline features

in the in-app “What’s new”

3

new interface languages

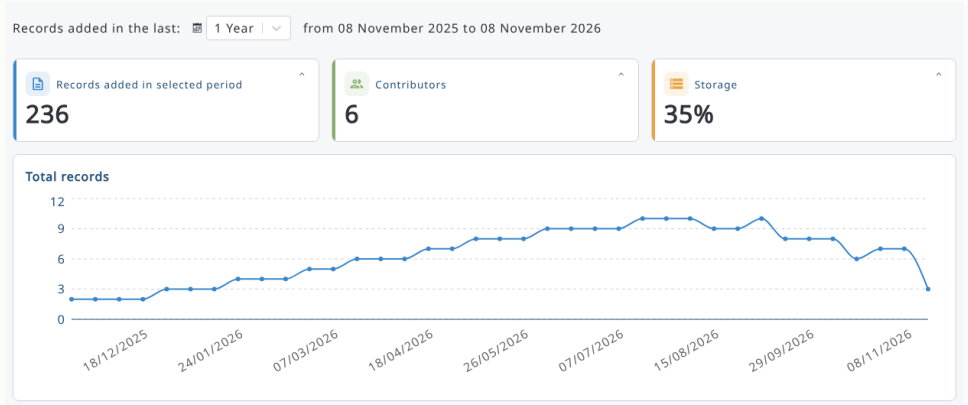
Portuguese, Japanese, Serbian



Arena · design, collect, clean and analyse data on the web, with Arena Mobile in the field

ARENA • EVERYONE

A fresh look: new dashboard and dark theme



New dashboard

Records, contributors and storage at a glance, a map of the data and the records trend.

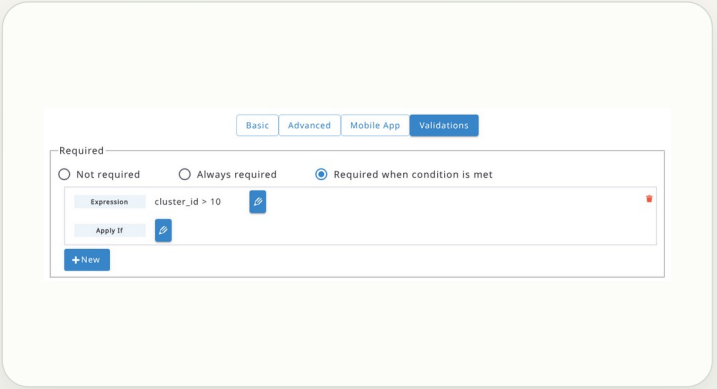


Light and dark theme

Switch from the header or the login page, or follow the system setting.

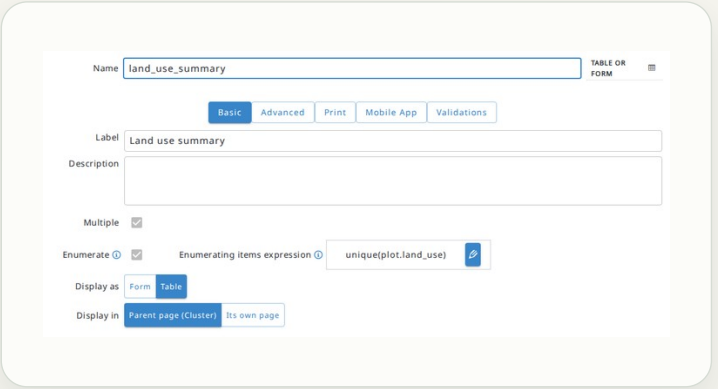
ARENA • SURVEY DESIGN

Smarter forms, less effort



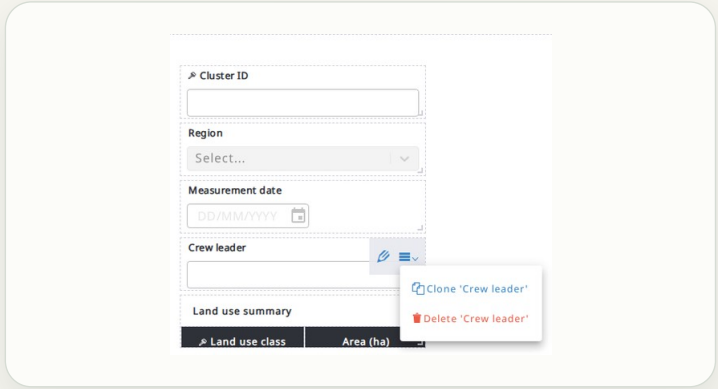
Required if

An attribute becomes mandatory only when a condition is true.



Dynamic enumerators

An expression decides which rows an enumerated entity gets.



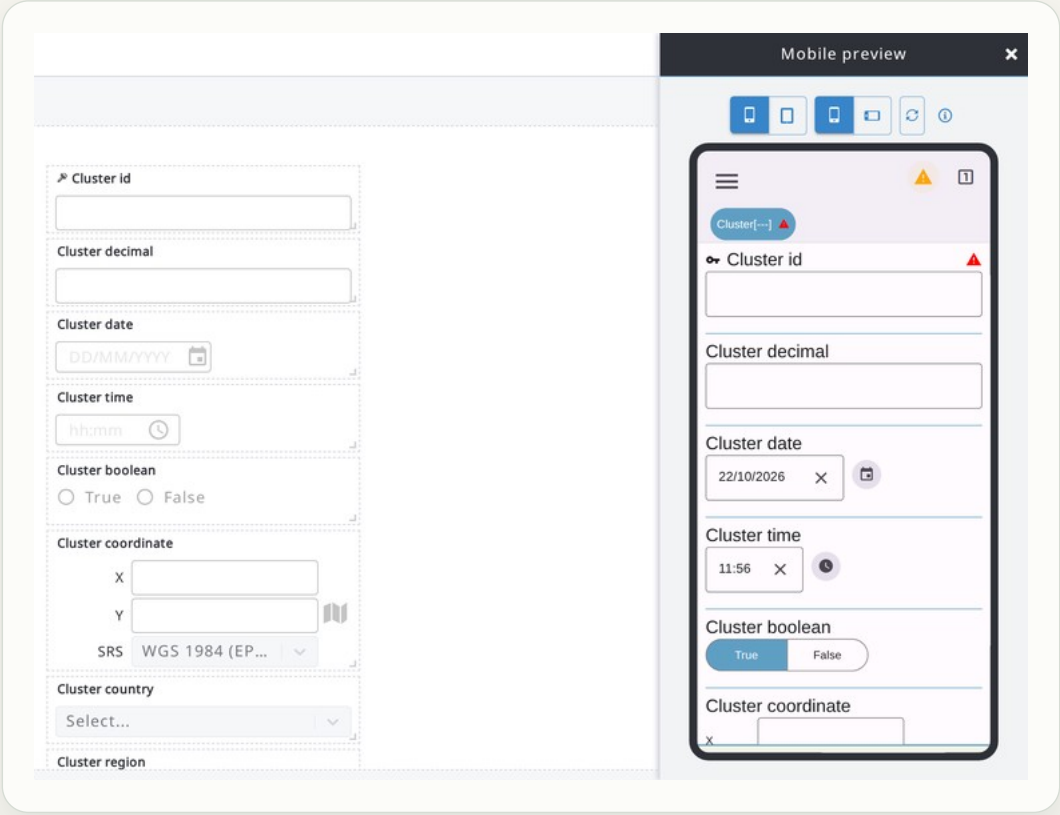
Clone attributes

Copy an attribute, with all its properties, into any entity.

Also: editable-if and visible-if · clone entities from another survey · publish warns about changes that affect existing data · time attributes with seconds

ARENA • SURVEY DESIGN

Preview your survey as it looks in Arena Mobile

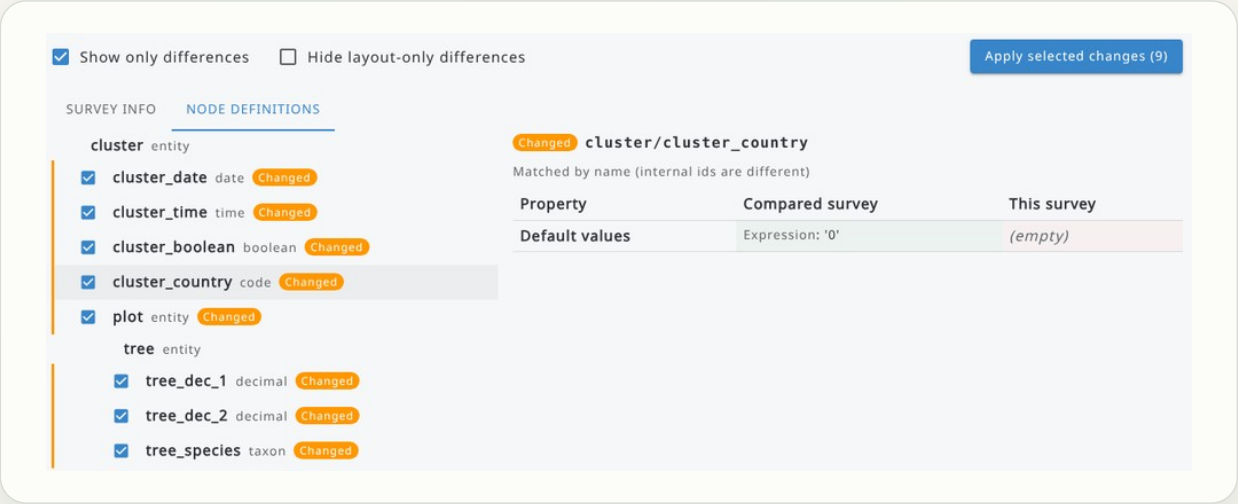


Open **Preview (mobile)** in the form designer and try the draft survey just as field teams will see it.

- Phone or tablet
- Portrait or landscape
- No device needed, it runs in the browser
- Available to every survey designer

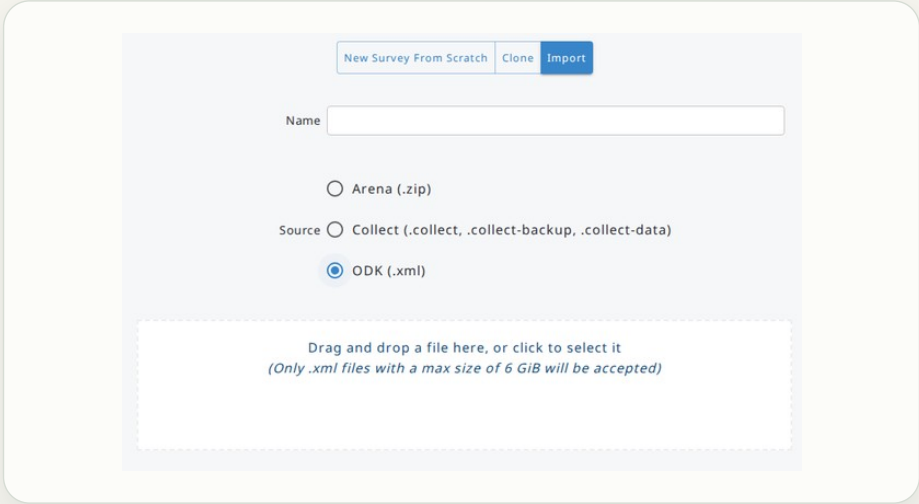
ARENA • SURVEY MANAGEMENT

Move surveys between servers and tools



Compare and update

Compare with a survey from another server (e.g. test → production) and apply only the changes you pick.

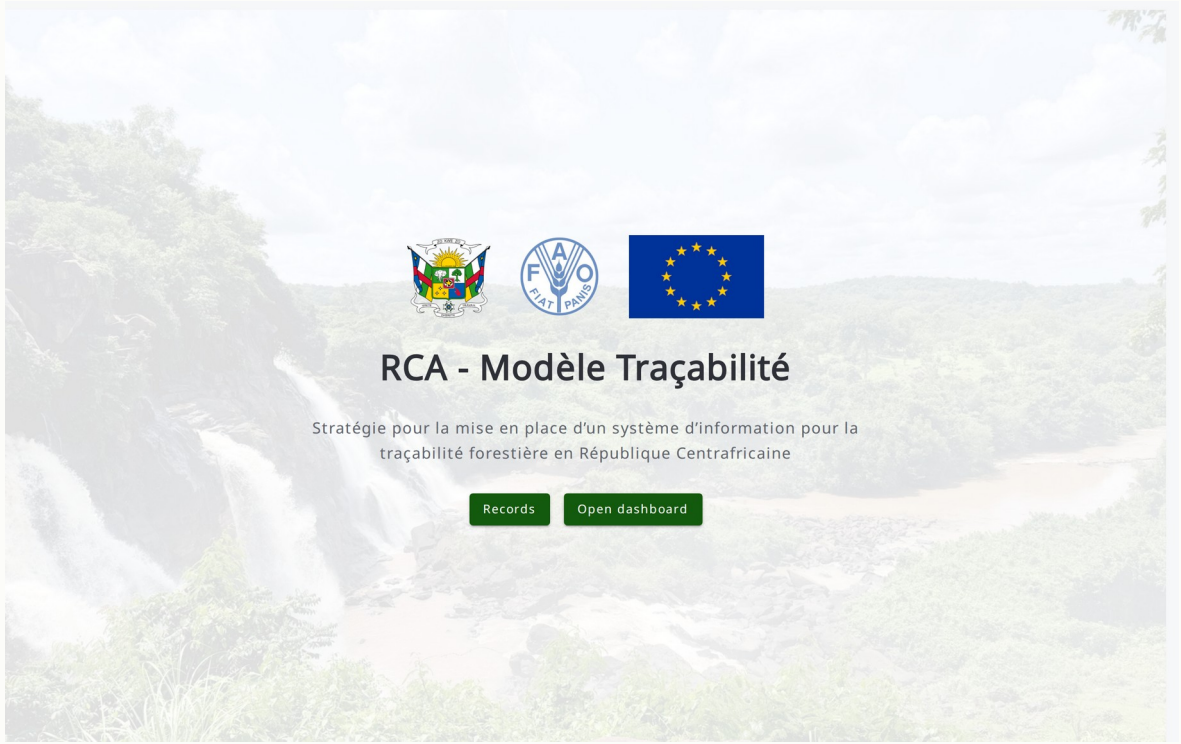


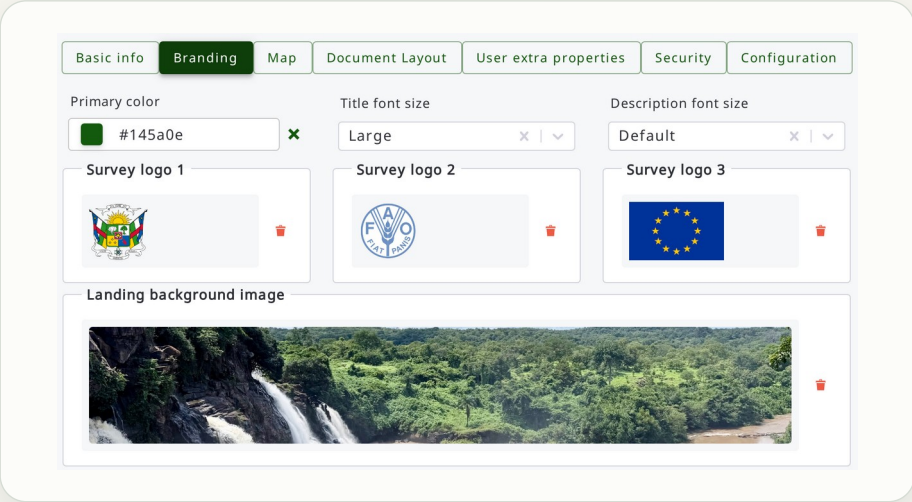
Import from ODK (beta)

Create a survey from an ODK form and import the data collected with ODK Collect.

ARENA • SURVEY ADMINS

Branding: each survey with its own look





- Up to 3 logos and a background image
- Primary colour applied to the whole app
- Title and description sizes, live preview

ARENA • DATA ENTRY

Print records, ready to file or share

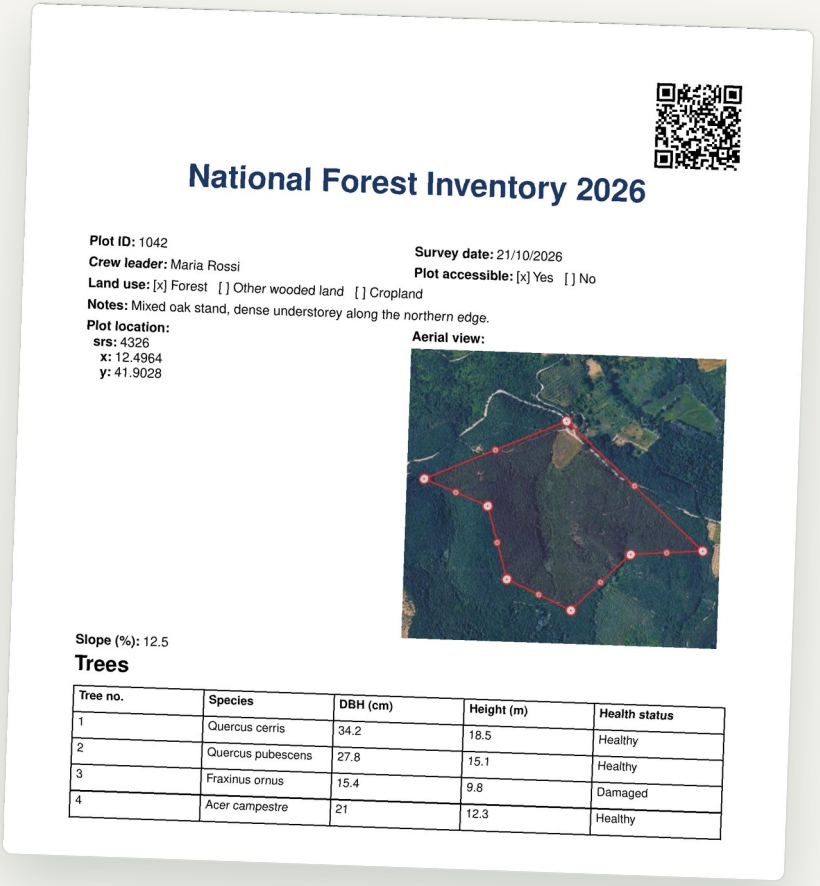
Word or PDF
The whole record or the current page, portrait or landscape.

Follows the form layout
Same columns as the form; multiple entities become tables.

Pictures included
Photos and other images from file attributes are printed.

QR code
Scan the page to open the record’s PDF online.

Your letterhead
Header and footer images, optional conditions, page numbers.



National Forest Inventory 2026

Plot ID: 1042
Crew leader: Maria Rossi
Land use: [x] Forest [ ] Other wooded land [ ] Cropland
Survey date: 21/10/2026
Plot accessible: [x] Yes [ ] No
Notes: Mixed oak stand, dense understorey along the northern edge.
Plot location:
srs: 4326
x: 12.4964
y: 41.9028
Aerial view:

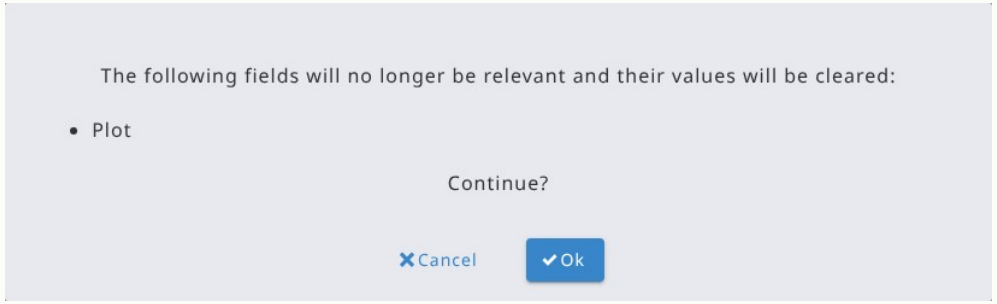
Slope (%): 12.5

Trees

Tree no.	Species	DBH (cm)	Height (m)	Health status
1	Quercus cerris	34.2	18.5	Healthy
2	Quercus pubescens	27.8	15.1	Healthy
3	Fraxinus ornus	15.4	9.8	Damaged
4	Acer campestre	21	12.3	Healthy

ARENA • DATA ENTRY

Cleaner data while you type



Non-relevant values cleared

When a change makes fields irrelevant, their values are cleared, after asking for confirmation.

- Export selected records in Arena format
- Selection kept when changing page
- Option to merge records with the same keys
- Minimum number of entities created automatically

ARENA • SECURITY

Safer access, finer control

Two-factor authentication

A code from an authenticator app at login; each code works only once.

QR code login

Sign in to Arena Mobile by scanning a code shown in Arena.

Group visibility

“Can view the records of”: read-only access to other groups’ records.

Access-aware exports

Record files, exports and mobile uploads limited to the records a group can access.

Data analysts

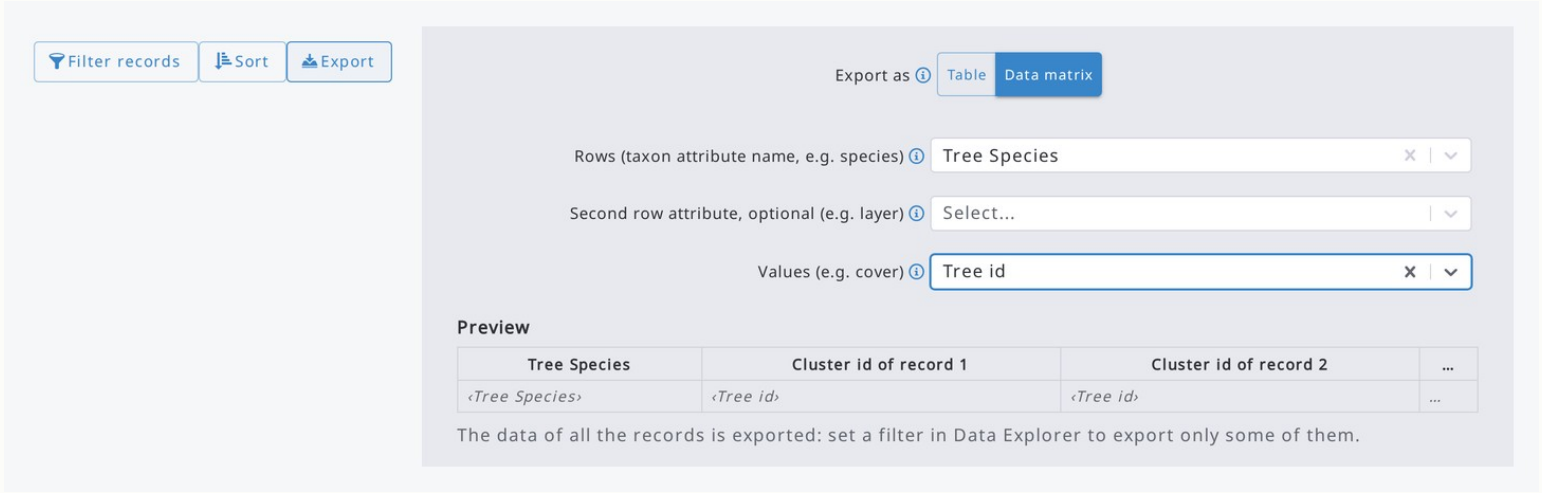
Survey option to let analysts see records they don’t own.

Hardened server

Request rate limiting and security updates all year.

ARENA • DATA EXPLORER

Explore and export your data



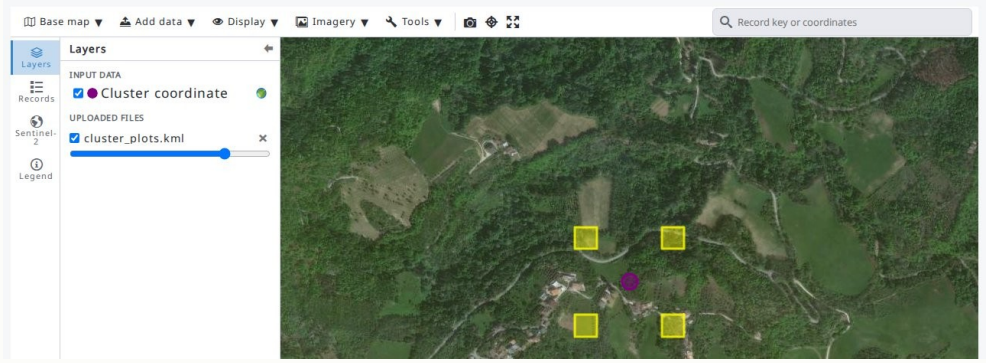
Data matrix export

Species × records tables, ready for vegetation analysis tools such as Turboveg, Juice and Synbiosys.

Also: totals and percentages in aggregate mode (new View menu) · charts on large data sets (random samples that keep the outliers) · JavaScript filter syntax with text search · queries generated by AI

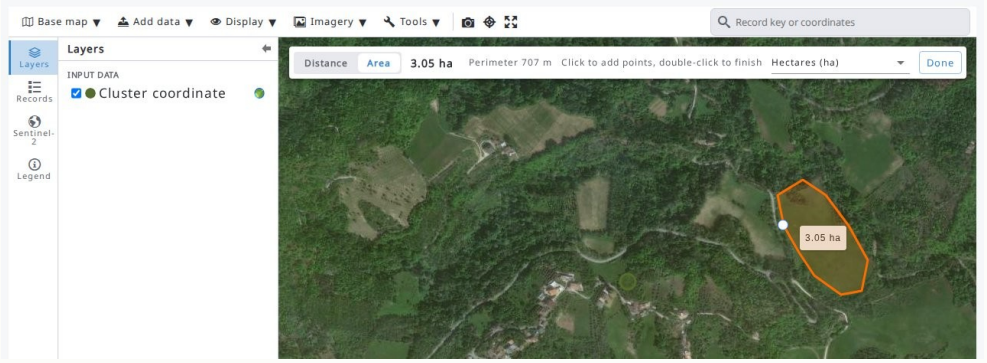
ARENA • MAPS

A new map workspace



Bring your own layers

KML, KMZ, Shapefile, GeoJSON, WMS / WMTS and XYZ tiles, for you or the whole survey.



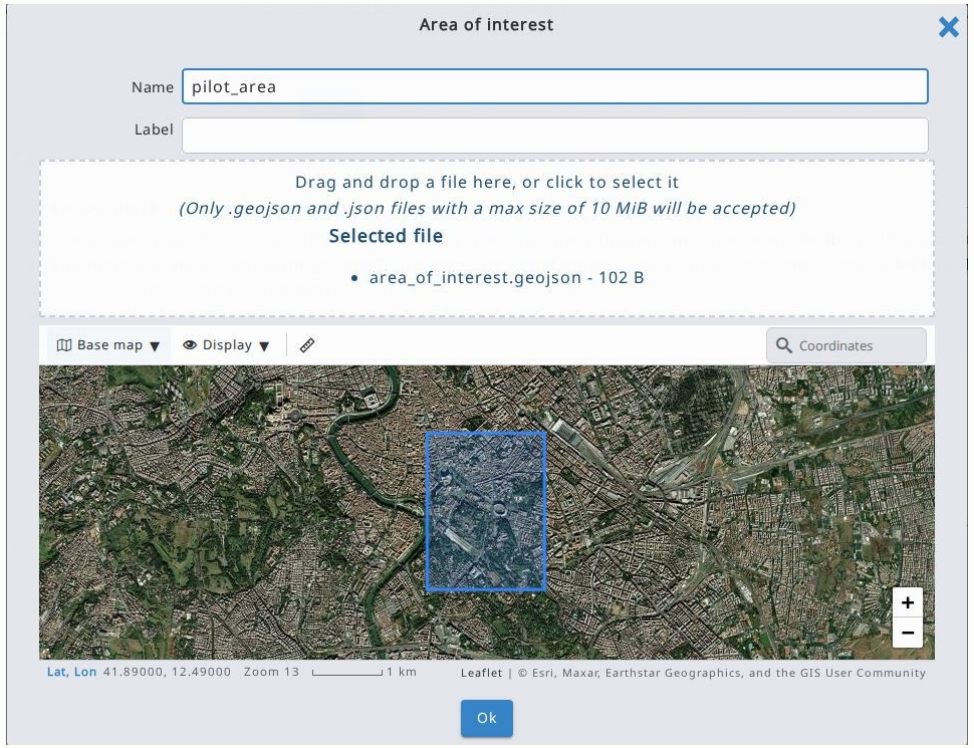
Measure and capture

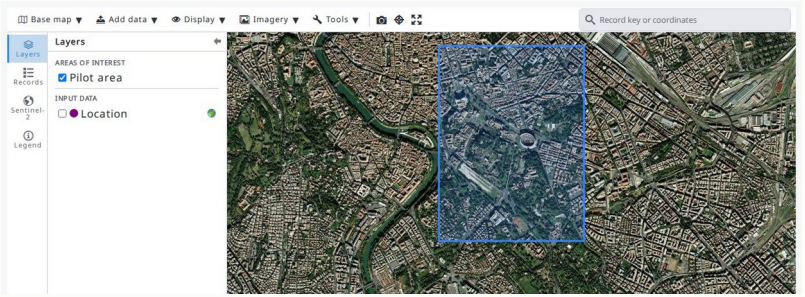
Distances and areas; screenshots saved as files or into a record.

Also: search by coordinates (decimal, DMS, UTM) or record keys · Records tab for everyone, with previous / next · Layers and Legend tabs · status bar with coordinates and scale

ARENA • NEW IN 2.12 • SURVEY DESIGN

Areas of interest: draw the line

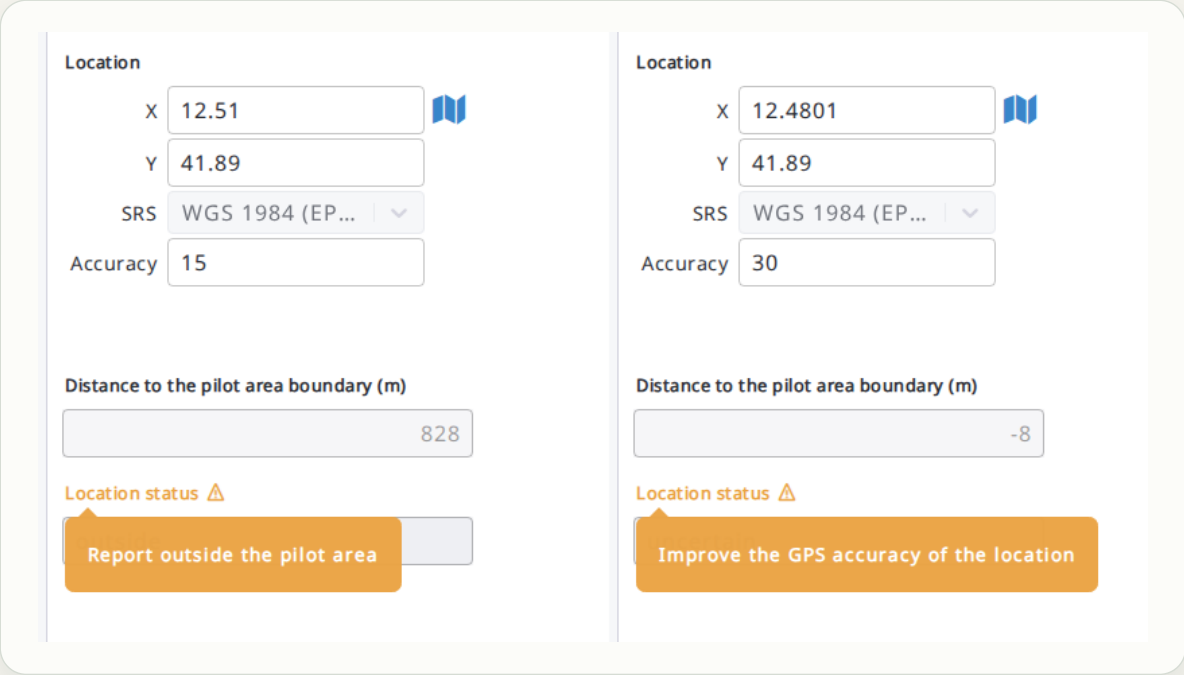




- One or more GeoJSON polygons per survey
- Checked on a map while you add them
- Shown as layers in Data > Map

ARENA • NEW IN 2.12 • EXPRESSIONS

Is the plot inside the area?



geoDistanceToAOIBoundary()

Distance in meters to the boundary of an area: negative inside, positive outside.

Inside, outside or uncertain

Compare the distance with the GPS accuracy and warn field teams on the spot.

geoAOIContaining()

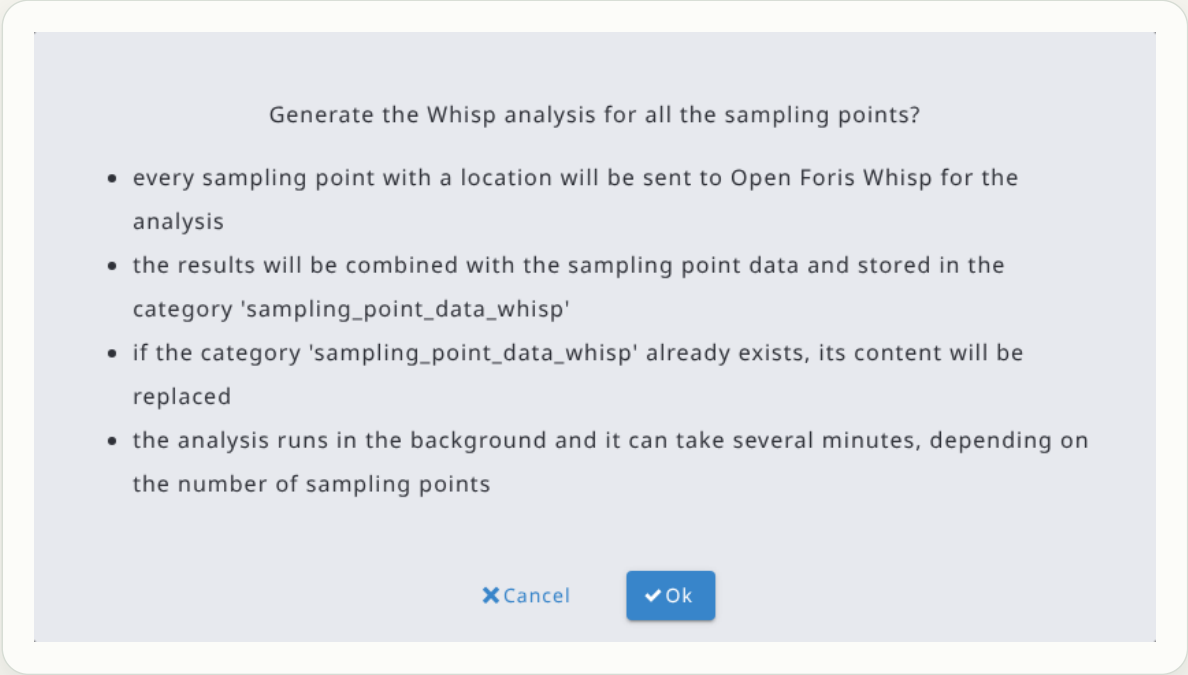
Returns the name of the area containing a location.

Offline in Arena Mobile

The same checks run in the field, with no connection.

ARENA • ANALYSIS

Whisp analysis and richer processing chains



Whisp, in the background

Analyse every sampling point with Open Foris Whisp; results are saved as a new category.

Two-phase sampling

Now supported in the chain editor, with better sampling design settings.

Area files and templates

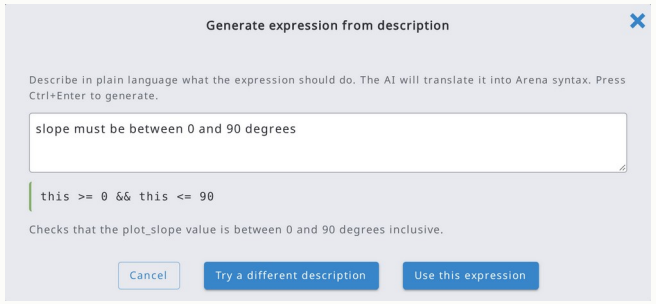
Area file (MAU) per cycle; clone chains from templates.

GeoPackage export

Export categories with their geometries.

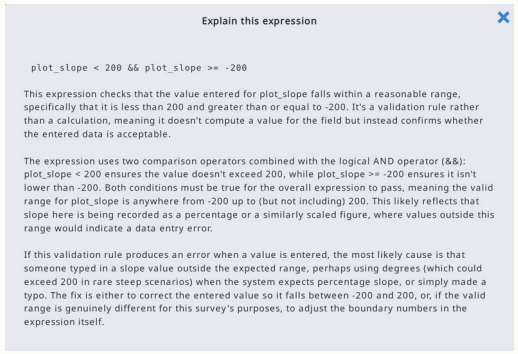
ARENA • AI ASSISTANT (OPTIONAL)

AI for survey designers



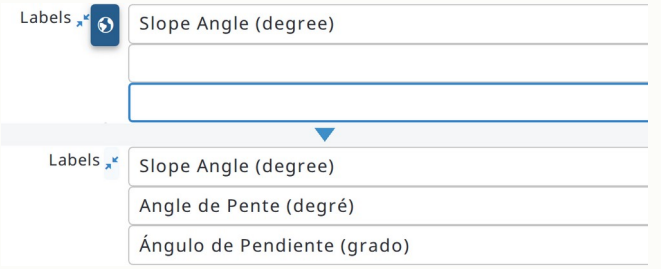
Expressions from plain language

Describe a rule; the AI writes it in Arena syntax and checks it before you use it.



Explain any expression

Validation rules, default values and conditions explained in plain language.



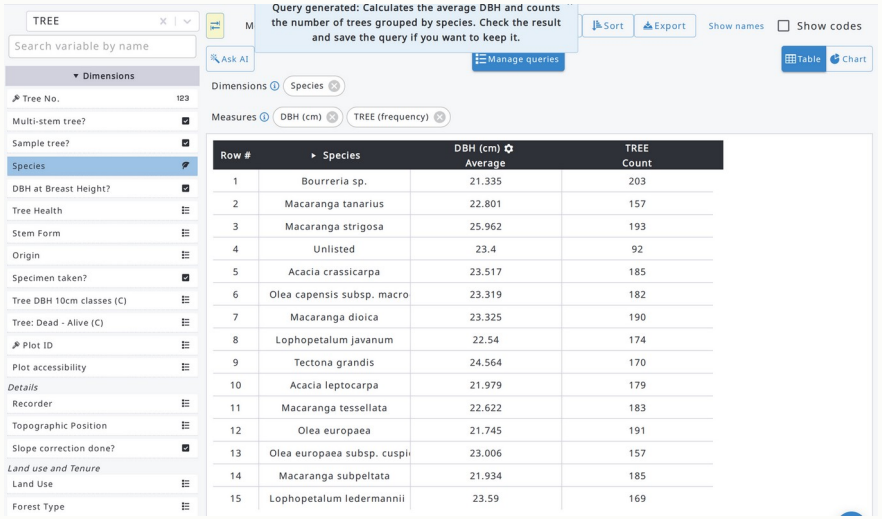
Translate labels

One click fills in the missing labels in all the survey languages.

Also: AI-drafted attribute descriptions in the data dictionary export

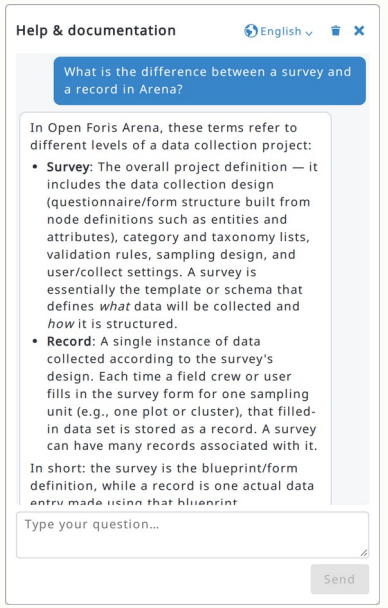
ARENA • AI ASSISTANT (OPTIONAL)

Ask in plain language



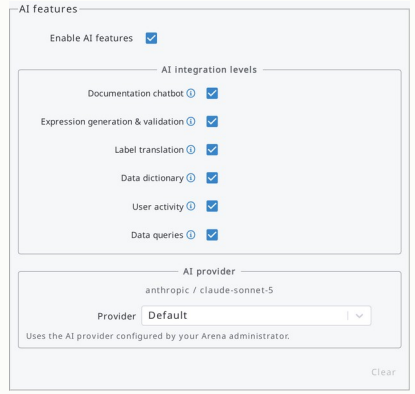
Data Explorer queries

“Average tree DBH and number of trees by species”: the AI picks entity, dimensions, measures and filters.



Help chatbot

Questions about Arena answered in the language you choose.



Your choice of AI

Anthropic, OpenAI, Google or OpenAI-compatible (also self-hosted), with your own key if you like.

UNDER THE HOOD

Faster where it matters

Minutes → seconds

to import Arena files with large records

Lighter records

less database space and memory for large records

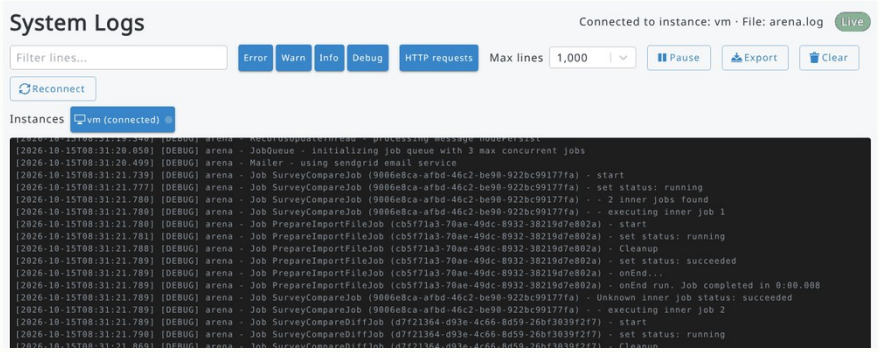
No duplicates

records merged by key on import and when they come from Arena Mobile

Plus faster record updates, data export and uploads from Arena Mobile.

ARENA • SYSTEM ADMINISTRATORS

Everything for system admins, on one page





- **System logs:** follow server logs live
- **Users backup / restore** between servers
- **Messages** in System Administration, also to survey admins only
- Email via **Amazon SES**
- Temporary files on **Amazon S3**
- Request rate limiting, single-use 2FA codes
- Activity log can be turned off
- Expired, never-activated accounts cleaned up
- Access request emails sent in BCC



Thank you

Full changelog and source code:

github.com/openforis/arena